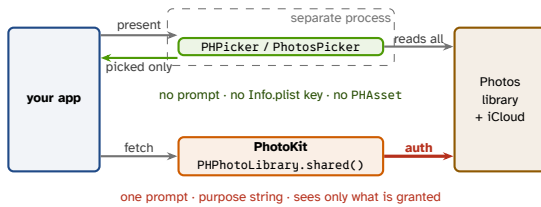
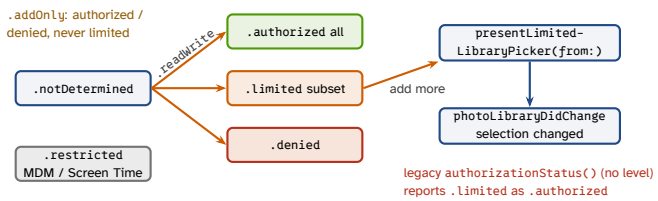


In one line: Two ways in. The **out-of-process picker** (PHPickerViewController 14, SwiftUI PhotosPicker 16) needs **no permission** — the app gets only the picked items. **PhotoKit** (PHPhotoLibrary, PHAsset, PHImageManager) is a live database behind **authorization**: `.readWrite` — which may come back **.limited**, a user-chosen subset (iOS 14) — or `.addOnly`. Picker unless you *are* a gallery, backup or editor app.

Two doors into the library



requestAuthorization(for:) — per access level



Door 1 — the picker

- Result = `PHPickerResult.itemProvider` (UIKit) or `PhotosPickerItem` (a Transferable placeholder). UIKit: `didFinishPicking` fires on Add and Cancel — **you dismiss**.
- Config: `selectionLimit` (default 1, 0 = no limit); filter `.images` `.videos` `.livePhotos` `.screenshots`, combined by `.any(of:)` `.all(of:)` `.not`; encoding `.current` (keep HEIC) vs `.compatible` (transcode).
- IDs** are nil unless built with `init(photoLibrary: .shared())` — required for `preselectedAssetIdentifiers` (15); fetching that `PHAsset` still needs authorization.
- Embedded, iOS 17:** `.photosPickerStyle(.inline)`, `selectionBehavior: .continuous` (live, no Add button), `.photosPickerDisabledCapabilities([.search, .stagingArea])`.

Example — picker, no permission

```

PhotosPicker(selection: $items, maxSelectionCount: 5,
  matching: .all(of: [.images, .not(.screenshots)]),
  preferredItemEncoding: .compatible) { Label("Add", systemImage: "photo") }
.task(id: items) {
  for item in items {
    // Image.self: PNG/JPEG only
    guard let d = try? await item.loadTransferable(type: Data.self)
    else { continue }
    // nil = type not offered
    thumbs.append(downsample(d, maxPixels: 600)) } } // never full size
  
```

Video: `FileRepresentation / loadFileRepresentation` — temp file **deleted when the handler returns**.

Door 2 — PhotoKit

- `PHAsset` = metadata (mediaType, pixelWidth, creationDate, localIdentifier); `PHAssetCollection` = album; `PHAssetResource` = the original files.
- `fetchAssets` → `PHFetchResult`: **lazy**, thread-safe, a **snapshot** (count fixed) — updates come as `PHChange`, often on a **background queue**.
- `requestImage(for:targetSize:contentMode:options:)`: size in **pixels**; keep the `PHImageRequestID`, `cancelImageRequest` on reuse. `isNetworkAccessAllowed` defaults **false** → iCloud-only asset: `PHImageResultIsInCloudKey`, no image.
- `PHCachingImageManager`: `startCachingImages` for rows about to appear — then request with the **same** size, mode, options, or it misses.
- Writes** only in `performChanges {}` (creation / change requests, `deleteAssets`); runs on a serial background queue; editing or deleting shows a **confirmation per call** — batch.

Which door?

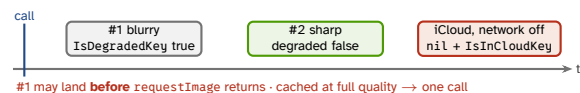
Avatar, attachment, “import to edit” → **picker**. Own gallery, backup, bulk edit → **.readWrite**, designed for **.limited** too. Camera app that only saves → **.addOnly**. Original bytes / RAW: `PHAssetResourceManager.writeData(for:toFile:options:)`.

Example — a PhotoKit grid

```

let s = await PHPhotoLibrary.requestAuthorization(for: .readWrite)
guard s == .authorized || s == .limited else { return showSettings() }
assets = PHAsset.fetchAssets(with: .image, options: newestFirst)
PHPhotoLibrary.shared().register(self) // PHPhotoLibraryChangeObserver
// cell: set the id BEFORE asking - the 1st callback can be synchronous
cell.assetID = asset.localIdentifier
cell.req = caching.requestImage(for: asset,
  targetSize: CGSize(width: side * scale, height: side * scale),
  contentMode: .aspectFill, options: opts) { img, info in
  guard cell.assetID == asset.localIdentifier else { return } // reused
  cell.image = img } // called twice: degraded, then final
  
```

One request, two answers



Live grid: `change.changeDetails(for: old) → on main` swap in `fetchResultAfterChanges`; `hasIncrementalChanges` ? batch **removed** → **inserted** → **moves** → **changed**: `reloadData()`.

Keys and the limited library

<code>NSPhotoLibraryUsageDescription</code>	<code>.readWrite</code> : read, edit, add
<code>NSPhotoLibraryAddUsageDescription</code>	<code>.addOnly</code> (iOS 11): save only
<code>PHPhotoLibraryPreventAutomaticLimitedAccessAlert</code>	YES = no auto “select more” prompt (default once per life cycle)
picker, PhotosPicker	nothing

.limited: fetches see only the selection; no user albums; assets you **create** join it; `presentLimitedLibraryPicker` (15: returns new ids) grows it. **IDs:** `localIdentifier` is per device — `PHCloudIdentifier` (15) across devices. **26.1:** `PHBackgroundResourceUploadExtension` (backup apps).

Traps

- Full library access to set an avatar — the picker needs no prompt and no key.
- `authorizationStatus()` without a level: `.limited` reads `.authorized` — “why 3 photos?”
- Image’s `Transferable` is PNG + JPEG only — load `Data` or your own type.
- `targetSize` in points, or `PHImageManagerMaximumSize` for a thumb: 48 MB per 12 MP.
- Cancel after preselection returns the *preselected* ids, not `[]`.

Remember

“Picker: no permission. PhotoKit: prompt, *limited* = subset. Pixels, twice, back to main.”